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"im embarrassed 2 say lol": The functions of *lol* in online groomer-decoy interactions

Sofia Navarro Beck

Aarhus University, Institute of Communication and Culture, Department of Linguistics, Cognitive Science and Semiotics, Denmark

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ABSTRACT

The present study examines a sample of the grooming chat-logs provided by the Perverted Justice Foundation (PJF) using a digital Conversation Analysis (CA) approach. I argue that many previous studies on online grooming discourse based on the PJF dataset have routinely overlooked key contextual and interactional features of these conversations. This is mainly due to the tendency to focus only on the groomers' utterances, while sytematically ignoring the decoys' contributions. In this study I demonstrate how by including both the groomers' and decoys' utterances it is possible to provide a more comprehensive understanding of groomer-decoy dynamics. By focusing specifically on the use of the discourse marker *lol* (laughing out loud), this study reveals that the decoys are active in shaping the entire interaction with the groomers, and that their use of *lol* plays a significant role in managing the conversation.

Recent years have seen an increase in the prevalence of vigilante so-called 'pedo-hunter' groups and their use of decoys to catch offenders worldwide. This study serves as a proof of concept, underscoring the relevance of examining the PJF data by applying microanalytic principles offered by CA. The article thus advocates for future sequential analyses of authentic grooming data to further advance our understanding of digital sexual offenses.

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1. Background

Although exact international statistics are difficult to find, according to a 2023 We Protect Global Alliance global survey, 54 % of children had experienced at least one type of online sexual harm (WeProtect Global Alliance, 2023, 10). As disturbing as the current statistics are, many experts agree that the incidence of child sexual abuse (CSA) has significantly risen with increases in internet access (WeProtect Global Alliance, 2021). In this article I focus on online grooming, a sub-type of CSA.

There is much research to indicate that survivors of online CSA (OCSA) may suffer a wide range of long-term negative effects, including heightened rates of severe anxiety, depression, self-harm, suicide ideation, and suicide (Plummer, 2018; Wolf and Pruitt, 2019; Naidoo and Van Hout, 2021). Consequently, OCSA is widely recognized as a global public health crisis (WHO 2024). Previous research in online grooming has provided important insights into the linguistic strategies used by sexual offenders during the online grooming process. However, it has tended to focus on offenders' language in isolation (e.g., Craven et al., 2006; McAlinden, 2012; Kloess et al., 2014; Kloess et al., 2017; Winters et al., 2017; Lorenzo-Dus and Kinzel,

E-mail address: snb@cc.au.dk.

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2019; Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2020; Lorenzo-Dus and Kinzel, 2021) with a few exceptions (e.g. Chiang and Grant, 2019; see also Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2023 for a comprehensive linguistic study on online grooming that includes the voices of children).

One reason for this one-sided focus is related to the nature of the available data, namely the dataset of grooming chat-logs provided by the Perverted Justice Foundation (PJF) (see Section 4 for a detailed description of this data). This dataset consists of chat-logs between convicted sex-offenders and 'decoys': adults posing as minors. Consequently, a consistent step in data preprocessing has been to find and remove all chat-lines written by decoys (e.g. Broome et al., 2020, 6) meaning that little is known about the intricacies specific to groomer-decoy interactions.

Even though the decoys' language is not representative of children's language there are still valid reasons for including it when studying this dataset. Firstly, the decoys' own contributions in the chats are paramount to how the entire conversation develops sequentially, and can impact the design of the groomers' contributions, as will be shown in this article. Furthermore, it is important to consider the special context in which the PJF chats came to be. The decoys are motivated by the ultimate goal of obtaining evidence against groomers to help secure their convictions, which in turn impacts the pattern of the entire conversation. Therefore, this qualitative study considers the interactional features of a sample of PJF chat-logs, meaning a focus on not just groomers' language use, but also on how decoys respond to groomers' attempts to engage sexually with them.

Previous studies have noted the discourse marker *lol* as a discursive strategy used by groomers to mitigate the seriousness of their sexual interactions with targets (Kloess et al., 2014; Chiang and Grant, 2017). Based on these initial observations, this qualitative study is operationalized in terms of the discourse marker *lol*, and aims to explore the pragmatic functions of *lol* in the PJF dataset and to examine whether its usage differs between decoys and groomers – and if so, in what ways.

The present study is intended as a proof of concept showcasing the usefulness of digital CA as a methodology to analyze the PJF data. On the basis of that methodology, it investigates what insights the discourse marker *lol* can provide into the specific dynamics of groomer-decoy chat interactions. A secondary goal is to provide a preliminary interactional characterization of the PJF dataset.[1]

2. Theoretical background

2.1. Conceptualizing online grooming

Child sexual grooming has received wide scholarly attention in the past two decades. However, given the enormous complexity of the phenomenon, there is still no universally accepted definition of it (Winters et al., 2022). In a recent study Winters et al. (2022) identified seven main problems and limitations characterizing previous definitions of grooming which need to be addressed in order to properly operationalize the concept *online grooming*.

Firstly, many definitions lack a specification that the intended outcome of grooming behavior is child sexual abuse and not just child abuse in general. Another common theme in previous definitions is that grooming is a conscious process, with offenders often being described as "skillfully manipulative" (McAlinden, 2007) and as acting consciously, deliberately and in a pre-mediated manner (Cano and Alani, 2014). However, there is no empirical evidence in support of this view of grooming, which is why this should not be explicitly denoted in a definition (Winters et al., 2022). Many definitions also restrict the types of offenders and victims, and use narrow terminology such as 'adult', 'boy', 'girl', 'teenager', 'child molester' and 'pedophile', which is innapropriate because sexual offenders, as well as victims of sexual offenses are heterogenous groups. For example, recent research on CSA shows that it is not always committed by adults (Pedersen, 2023), and that "any child or adolescent may be at risk to be victimized" (Winters et al., 2022, 930). A further problem is the tendency to include what Winters et al. (2022, 930) term "compliance terminology" in definitions, which refers to words and phrases that imply consent on the part of the victim, such as, 'engage', 'permit' and 'acquiesce'. Because of the inherently non-consensual nature of child grooming, the use of these terms is problematic. Some definitions also specify certain behaviors involved in grooming, such as, befriending children (Gillespie, 2002) or trying to hide their actions from others (Leberg, 1997), which is inappropriate because it increases the likelihood of both false negative and false positive identifications of grooming (Winters et al., 2022). In other words, grooming can happen with or without the presence of certain behaviors and they should thus not be explicated in a definition.

Finally, there are inconsistencies related to whether the grooming process extends to caregivers and the wider community, as well as to whether it involves post-abuse victim maintenance. In defining grooming, Winters et al. (2022) recommend noting that others *may* be involved in the grooming process and that post-abuse victim maintenance *may* be part of the grooming process.

Issues like the above are reflected in the literature on online grooming where there are terminological disagreements and inconsistencies in the descriptions of the behaviors involved in the process (Choo, 2009; Babchishin et al., 2011; Cano and Alani, 2014; Black et al., 2015; al-Khateeb and Epiphaniou, 2016). In the context of studying the phenomenon from a linguistic perspective, there is one additional limitation, namely that online grooming is, by necessity, a communicative

[1] In addition to this methodological demonstration, this study lays the groundwork for my current PhD research in which I examine authentic online grooming chats using digital CA.

practice carried out through language use. Based on all these considerations, I adopt and modify Winters et al.'s (2022, 933) definition of physical grooming to fit the digital context: *Online sexual grooming is a deceptive communicative practice used by sexual abusers to facilitate sexual contact with a minor.*

2.2. *Previous characterizations of* lol

Lol was initially an internet-specific acronym for the phrase 'laughing out loud' (O'Neill, 2010). However, it has since been argued that *lol* "has become lexicalized as a unit distinct from laughing out loud, possibly as something like an uninflected discourse marker" (Garley et al., 2009, 124). This discourse marker, along with other acronyms like *wtf* ('what the fuck') or 'btw' ('by the way') "have been conventionalized to serve as markers of group membership among Internet users" (Garley et al., 2009, 124). In spite of its lexicalization, *lol* has still been characterized as a strategy used in textual computer-mediated-communication (CMC) to transcribe laughter (Vandergriff and Fuchs 2012, 450).

Just as laughter in face-to-face interactions serves multiple functions, such as, to respond to improprieties (Jefferson et al., 1984; Glenn and Holt, 2017), to downplay (samtalegrammatik.dk 2020) as an instruction to hear, as a marker of understanding (O'Donnell-Trujillo and Adams, 1983), to accomplish affiliation (Jefferson, 1985) etc., the discourse marker *lol* is multifunctional as well. Not only can it serve multiple functions, but studies also show that the function (and thus meaning) of *lol* is largely dependent on its surrounding context and its syntactical position in the utterance (Markman, 2013). Schneebeli (2020) broadly found that *lol* can express amusement or alignment, and mark the illocutionary force of an utterance, depending on its syntactical position. Similarly, Markman (2013) noted that the function of *lol* used in Instant Message (IM) conversations between college students changed, depending on whether it was used in the beginning or the end of a message. Based on his study, Markman (2013) argues that turn-initial *lol* can serve as a turn-taking device, meaning that a participant will use it as a bridge between their own turns, whereas *lol* in turn-final position takes on a function akin to tag questions used in face-to-face talk like 'you know', marking conversational valence, i.e., whether people have a relatively positive or negative stance towards the topic they are discussing (Hendriks et al., 2014).

The meaning of *lol* can thus be said to be derived from the phrase 'laughing out loud', from which it retains part of its original meaning, while simultaneously adopting a variety of other pragmatic functions that are context dependent.

Lol has also been noted as a feature of grooming chats by previous researchers and suggested to have mitigating, diminishing or playful functions. It has also been suggested that when *lol* is used by offenders it is usually in sexual contributions (Kloess et al., 2014; Chiang and Grant, 2017). While this study acknowlegdes that *lol* can indeed serve these functions, it also demonstrates that the discourse marker serves other functions, especially when used by the targets.

2.3. Lol *in online grooming conversations*

There are two studies which specifically note the use of *lol* in online grooming coversations. In one study, Chiang and Grant, (2017) used Swales' move analysis on a sample of the PJF data to identify common rhetorical moves used by groomers (Chiang and Grant, 2017). They suggested *lol* as a feature possibly connected to two of the identified moves, namely Sexual Rapport and Assessing and Managing Risk. Specifically, they posit that *lol* has a mitigating or diminishing function, and that offenders use it deliberately as a way of "guarding against anticipated rejection" or as an attempt to ease the targets into discussing sexual topics (Chiang and Grant, 2017, 116). In terms of Assessing and Managing Risk the authors suggest that the presence of *lol* could serve as an argument for defense lawyers to claim that the offenders' contributions were jokes or otherwise not meant seriously. Chiang and Grant's (2017) article also suggests that *lol* is mostly used in contributions that are explicitly sexual but that it is not present in non-sexual rapport building.

In another study, Kloess et al. (2014) used thematic analysis on a sample of real grooming chats between convicted offenders and children aged 11–15 from the UK, focusing exclusively on the groomers' utterances. They identified four themes that characterized how groomers performed the "action (…) of sexual grooming" (Kloess et al., 2014: 567). They specifically noted the groomers' frequent use of *lol* under the theme of Pursuing Sexual Information and further argue that its use gives "the impression that the interaction is more an act than of any seriousness" (Kloess et al., 2014: 581).

These analytical takes are validated in this study and further expanded to demonstrate how *lol* may also be used in other ways.

3. Method

3.1. *Digital CA*

For this study I employ digital Conversation Analysis (CA), a method which draws on concepts and perspectives from traditional CA (Sidnell and Stivers 2013) and applies them to digitally mediated conversations (Giles et al., 2015; Meredith, 2019; Jucker 2021; Koivisto et al., 2023). A central idea behind CA is that conversations are organized sequentially, and that speakers design and produce their turns with an orientation to what came before in the talk (Heritage and Clayman, 2010). Previous researchers have studied online grooming conversations using various forms of discourse analysis and speech act theory (Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2023), genre analysis (Chiang and Grant, 2017), and thematic analysis (Kloess et al., 2017). But contrary to discourse analysis "CA focuses on how interaction unfolds moment-by-moment and how participants

themselves make sense of each other's contributions in this sequentially organised interaction" (Koivisto et al., 2023, 8). This allows the analyst to see how the available linguistic resources are being used to perform various social actions on a turn-by-turn basis.

The rationale behind CA can also be applied to analyzing digital conversations, while still acknowledging that talk-in-interaction differs from online interactions, and that the latter could perhaps more appropriately be described as conversation-like (Giles et al., 2015, 45). In terms of this study, there are two main CA concepts which are relevant to outline in more detail, namely that of a *turn* and that of a *project*.

3.2. 'Turns' and 'projects' in digitally mediated conversations

In CA a 'turn' is defined as the "basic unit of conversation" (Sidnell, 2010, 36), and in their seminal paper Sacks et al. (1974, 702) proposed that turns are made up of Turn-Constructional Units (TCUs): linguistic units such as sentences, clauses, phrases, and lexical constructions, as well as prosodical features, such as, intonation. A TCU performs an action (e.g., a request, a question, a confirmation etc.), and signals or projects its possible completion to the interlocutor, thus allowing speakers to anticipate when turn-transitions are possible.

Given the asynchronous nature of digitally mediated conversations "a text can only be responded to once it has been composed, sent, and received" (Hutchby and Tanna, 2008, 146) making the projectability of turns unavailable to the participants. One solution to the issue of projectability in digital conversations is to distinguish between messages and TCUs/turns (Koivisto et al., 2023, 9). This distinction can be necessary because the internal composition of messages varies according to whether they are 'package-texts' or 'simple-format' texts. Package-texts refers to messages composed of multiple TCUs, e.g., a greeting followed by a formulaic inquiry and a topic initiation, each of which can in turn be "treated sequentially implicative in its own right" (Hutchby and Tanna, 2008, 153; Koivisto et al., 2023, 10). In other words, the recipient may reply to each of these bits one at a time. Simple format texts, on the other hand, refers to a way of texting known as chunking: "the breaking down of single utterances into several components, which are then transmitted seriatim, rather than typing out the entire utterance and then transmitting it all" (Markman, 2015, 65–66).

While this distinction is important, the participants in my data sample do not make use of simple-format texts or chunking as a resource (there are a few instances where one participant sends multiple messages following one another, but these are all syntactically complete). As such, for the purpose of this study, a turn is defined as a single *message*. So, if one participant sends multiple messages in a row, each of those messages would constitute a turn of their own in this conceptualization. Furthermore, I identify four positions within a turn in which *lol* can occur:

Turn-initial: When *lol* is the first word in a message.

Turn-medial: When *lol* occurs between words in a message.

Turn-final: When *lol* is the last word in a message.

Stand-alone: When *lol* is the only word in a message.

This subdivision of *lol* allows me to conduct a close qualitative analysis of the groomer-decoy interactions, with the goal of determining some of *lol*'s most prominent functions in this context.

This study is interested in examining what the participants in the PJF *do*, i.e. their actions, which is why the notion of a 'project' is relevant. The term project or action plan is "a course of action that at least one participant is pursuing, which may at first be opaque to others then retrospectively discernible (…), and then prospectively projectable" (Levinson 2012, 122). As previously mentioned, and as will become evident in section 6, the decoys and groomers in the PJF dataset are carrying out two different projects. These differing projects play a large role in determining the functions of *lol* and the contexts in which they occur.

4. Data, ethical issues, and procedure

For reasons of transparency and because this study makes use of the PJF dataset, I wish to first recognize, acknowledge and discuss some prominent ethical issues associated with the PJF as an organization.

The PJF was an American citizen-based organization in which volunteers conducted sting-operations to identify, catch, and prosecute child sexual offenders (Kohm, 2009). Their operations were carried out with the use of adults posing as minors online. In collaboration with US law-enforcement, the PJF's primary mission was to secure the conviction of child sex-offenders. When a conviction was secured, the corresponding chat-log along with pictures and personal information of offenders were uploaded to the PJF website. Accordingly, the 613 chat-logs that were (until early 2024) available on www.perverted-justice.com, consist of written chat-conversations in which convicted sex-offenders display grooming behavior with adults whom they believe to be minors.

The main criticisms towards the PJF predominantly target its controversial tactics in terms of legal procedures (Gaeta, 2010). For example, several media articles (ABC, 2004; Salkin, 2006; Sullum, 2011; Presnell, 2023) as well as some scholarly articles (e.g. Egan et al., 2011; Winters et al., 2017) have discussed the issue of whether the PJF chat-logs were obtained

through legal entrapment, i.e., whether the decoys endorsed the groomers' behavior such that they essentially encouraged them to commit a crime. In addition, the PJF and its members have been accused of allegedly encouraging the extrajudicial shaming and harassment of the individuals posted on their website, even though they had not yet been convicted of any crime (Kohm, 2009).

This last accusation is important, because it is directly connected with the preventive aspect of working on the topic of CSA. The ultimate goal of the CSA research community is to contribute with knowledge and actions that can aid in the prevention of CSA. Even though the PJF presented itself as an organization that sought to fight CSA – a sentiment reproduced by many researchers using their data (e.g. Black et al., 2015) – its actions and moral driving force can be argued to have contributed to the opposite. On their website the PJF categorized chat-logs according to "most slimy" and referred to offenders as "predators" or "wannabe pedos". They also collaborated with Dateline NBC's popular television show "To Catch a Predator" in which offenders who had chatted with decoys were confronted by cameras, journalists and eventually law enforcement agents, exposing their identity and personal information on national television for entertainment (Gaeta, 2010).

These kinds of sentiments towards offenders were heavily advocated by the PJF. However, the terms *pedophile* and *child sexual* abuser are often confused and mistakenly used interchangeably (Pedersen, 2023). The latest research focusing on pedophilia has also found that "the stigmatization of people who are sexually attracted to children is a prominent concern for child sexual abuse prevention" (Pedersen 2023, ii) and "punitive attitudes in society can lead to detrimental psychological effects which have been associated with an increased risk of offending" (Pedersen, 2023, ii). Nonetheless, mass-mediated humiliation has become an increasingly commodified enactment of justice in pop-culture, and media researchers have studied how this practice "subverts the prevailing law and order' ideology" (Kohm, 2009, 201).

While this was by no means an exhaustive list of ethical challenges related to the PJF, I feel compelled to open a candid discussion about some of them to gain a more nuanced view of how their data came to be.

4.1. Data

The PJF chat-logs were downloaded from their website in 2022 when they were still publicly available and stored securely and GDPR compliant. However, in February 2024 the PJF closed down their website and, for reasons unknown, removed the chat-logs which are no longer available. Because of this, when presenting data examples, all usernames and other personal identifiers are anonymized. When showing excerpts of chat-transcripts, offenders are marked as **Groomer** and targets as **Decoy**.

10 chat-logs from the PJF were selected based on the following criteria: 1.) *Lol* was present between 30 and 100 times in each chat-log, and 2.) each chat-log contained a different groomer. The final dataset thus consists of 10 chat-logs of conversations between 10 groomers and decoys that took place in 2007, 2014 and 2016. The sample is made up of 60.000 words, and the discourse marker *lol* occurs a total of 617 times.

As there is no information about the decoys other than their usernames, the real number of individual decoys in the sample is unknown. The real gender of the decoys is also unknown, however all the decoys in the data presented as female, so female pronouns are used to refer to them. The real gender of the offenders in the PJF dataset is exclusively male, and thus male pronouns are used to refer to them throughout. Time-stamps were not available for all the chats in the sample, so they have only been included in the examples whenever possible.

4.2. Procedure

Before coding the data, I performed a close reading of all 10 chat-logs in order to familiarise myself with the sample. Assisted by the statistical program R I counted all instances of *lol* in the entire PJF dataset (all 613 files) and then coded them according to whether *lol* was written by the decoy or the groomer. I then counted and coded all instances of *lol* in the sample of 10 chat-logs and classified each instance according to its position within the message: 1) turn-initial, 2) turn-medial, 3) turn-final, and 4) stand-alone.

After a second close reading of all 10 chat-logs, eight excerpts were chosen for qualitative analysis. This step required looking at turns adjacent to where *lol* occurred, i.e., both before and after *lol*. The number of adjacent turns was decided on the basis of the individual example, but generally the structure of the sequence was considered when deciding how many turns to include. The qualitative analysis led to the identification and description of four main functions of *lol* which are described in Section 5.2.

5. Quantitative distribution of *lol*

In relation to RQ 2 there is a clear quantitative difference in terms of the frequency *lol* is used by groomers and decoys. Across the entire PJF dataset, the discourse marker *lol* was used more than twice as often by decoys (n = 81341) than by groomers (n = 36048). This stark difference is visualized in Fig. 1 below.

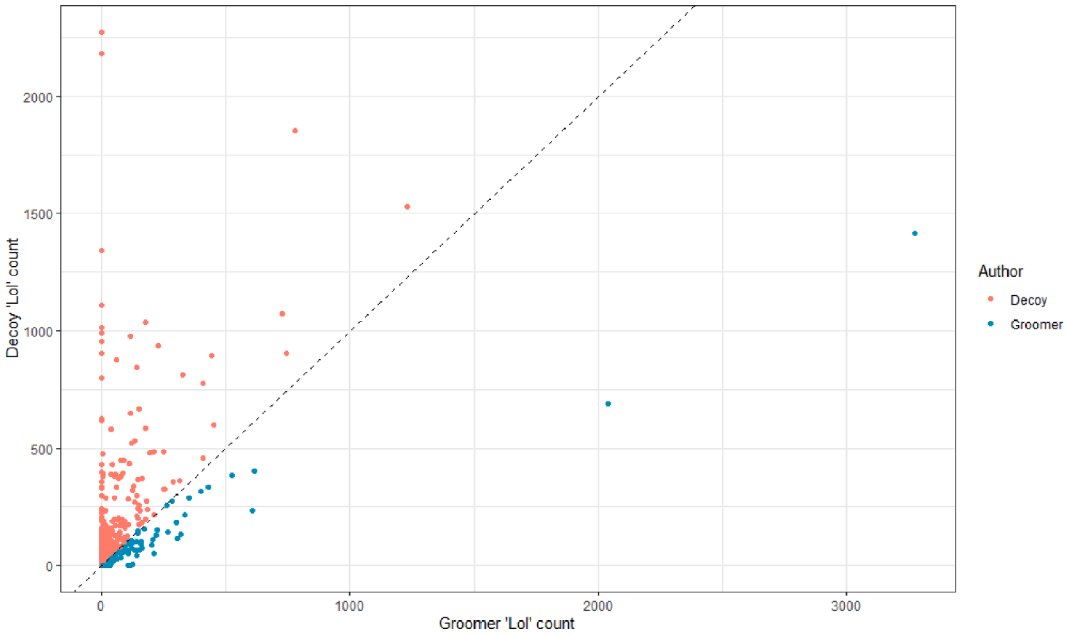

Fig. 1. Difference in the usage of *lol* across decoys (red) and groomers (blue). (For interpretation of the references to color in this figure legend, the reader is referred to the Web version of this article.)

As already mentioned, it is not possible to differentiate between individual decoys, however we do know that each chat-log contains a different groomer. Fig. 2 below illustrates how often each individual groomer in the PJF dataset uses *lol*. Each black point represents one groomer.

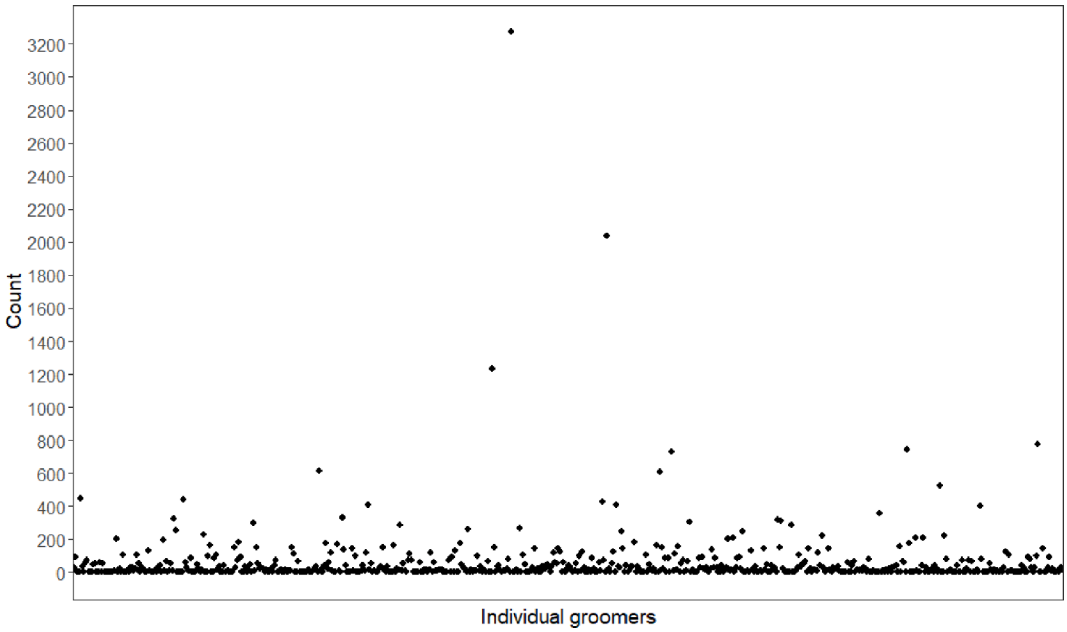

Fig. 2. Groomers' usage of *lol* across the entire PJF dataset.

The plot in Fig. 2 shows that most points are concentrated between 0 and 100, and that the next-biggest concentration of points lies between 100 and 800. Then, there are three outliers who are responsible for 18 % of the total amount of *lol*s used by groomers: one at 1232, one at 2040, and thirdly at 3272. The main limitation of this analysis is that it does not consider possible cases of *lol* having been written more than once per line.

A closer examination of the sample of 10 chat-logs reflects the overall pattern that decoys use *lol* more frequently (n = 374 out of 2941 turns, 12.7 %) than groomers (n = 243 out of 3437 turns, 7 %). Using the statistical program R, a chi-square test of independence was performed to examine whether this difference was signficant, the null hypothesis (H0) being that there is no difference between how often the two groups use *lol*. The test showed a significant difference between the two groups' use of *lol*, $p < 0.01$ using an alpha level of 0.05.

Fig. 3 below visualizes the frequencies of *lol*'s distribution across turn-positions for both groups in the sample. Each groomer has received a code 'G1', 'G2' etc. and all decoys have been grouped together.

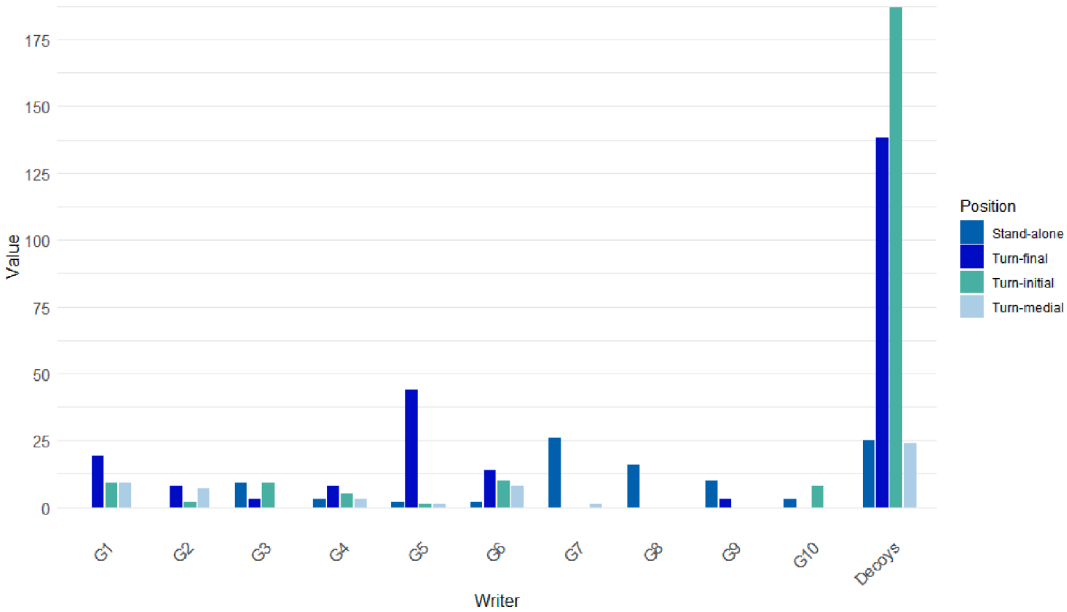

Fig. 3. Distribution of *lol* across turn-positions in the sample.

As Fig. 3 shows, groomers mostly use *lol* turn-finally and in stand-alone position, whereas decoys use it mostly turn-initially and turn-finally. Section 6 below presents eight excerpts of data that exemplify and provide possible explanations for this distribution.

6. Functions of *lol*

Here I characterize some situations in which *lol* tends to occur. In general, I found that when *lol* is used turn-initially it serves mainly one broad function which is that of orienting back to the previous turn, usually by taking a stance on it. When used turn-finally *lol* modifies the whole turn or modifies how the entire turn orients to what came before, which I will also show in the analysis below. In stand-alone position *lol* has a function more akin to an interjection, typically taking a negative stance to what came before. The turn-medial *lol*s, i.e. the ones that occurred between words in the same message, took on the function of either turn-initial or turn-final *lol*s depending on their exact syntactic position.

6.1. "No way lol": explaining why it is not possible to engage in sexual activity

One way *lol* is frequently used by decoys is to account for, i.e. explain why, they are unable rather than unwilling to participate in or engage with groomers' proposed sexual activity right now, or with propositions that have the potential to lead to something sexual in the future. Example [1.a.] below is an illustration of this. In the example *lol* occurs twice, once on line 7 uttered by the groomer and once on line 10 uttered by the decoy. The analysis focuses on the *lol* on line 10.

Example [1.a.]

1 Groomer (2:39 PM):	Uggh do u have skype?
2 Decoy (2:39 PM):	Nope
3 Groomer (2:40 PM):	What would it take for u to get it?
4 Decoy (2:42 PM):	My mom took away my web cam
5 Groomer (2:42 PM):	You can still watch get it for me
6 Decoy (2:44 PM):	I have yahoo?
7 Groomer (2:45 PM):	Thatll work **lol** im about to be home. Whats your yahoo?

8 Decoy (2:46 PM): I'm going to my grammas.. But it's [e-mail]
9 Groomer (2:46 PM): You dont want to watch me on cam?
10 Decoy (2:47 PM): **Lol** I do but were leaving
11 Decoy (2:47 PM): Add me n I'll go on later tonight when we get home
12 Groomer (2:48 PM): Your just suddenly leaving huh?

The decoy's turn on line 10 is initiated with 'Lol' followed by 'I do', which is a modified repeat of the groomer's formulation on the previous line 'You **dont** want … ' (line 9). In fact, what happens on line 10 is a direct result of the groomer's turn on line 9. Here, the groomer orients towards the decoy's rejection of going on yahoo soon (line 8), and provides a candidate account, that is, an account formulating a reasonable circumstance in his view for the decoy's rejection (Bolden and Robinson, 2011). This candidate account, which is designed as a declarative question with negative polarity, formulates the gist of the conversation so far and is put forward as a possible explanation for the decoy's actions. It is also pointing out a potentially serious problem in the interaction: that the decoy will not comply with the groomer's request. In line 10 the decoy deals with this potential problem by first forcefully rejecting the inbuilt interpretation that she does not 'want to' watch on 'cam'. She then further accounts for why she is unable to by invoking the agency of others ('**were** leaving'), thus disclaiming responsibility for the situation. All of this is prefaced by 'Lol' which in this instance seems to prepare for an upcoming account.

Accounts, i.e. justifications, explanations or excuses, are a common feature of refusals as CA has repeatedly shown (Potter and Wetherell, 1987; Kitzinger and Frith, 1999). However, the role that *lol* plays in refusals done in online settings has received scant attention.

A similar situation is observed in Example [1.b.] where the decoy provides a rejection to the inquiry of whether she can 'get out of the house' (line 3).

Example [1.b.]

1 Groomer (9:33 PM): so whats up
2 Decoy (9:34 PM): nm
3 Groomer (9:34 PM): can you get out of the house
4 Decoy (9:36 PM): tonight?
5 Decoy (9:36 PM): no way **lol**
6 Decoy (9:36 PM): mom is up and around
7 Groomer (9:36 PM): just asking

On line 5 we again see 'lol' accompanying a forceful rejection 'no way', which is then followed up by an explanation on line 6, which like in Example [1.a.] invokes the agency of others ('mom is up and around').

6.2. Disaffiliation and avoidance in sexually explicit sequences

A salient feature of the PJF data is that the offenders and the decoys are carrying out different projects during the conversation: the offender is attempting to manipulate what they believe to be a child to engage in sexually abusive situations, while the decoys are managing two considerations simultaneously: 1) keeping the offender engaged and active so they can eventually be caught and prosecuted, and 2) balancing how much they go along with the offender without crossing legal boundaries (entrapment), which could result in the chat-logs not being admissible in court.

As a result, the decoys often pull away whenever the topic turns overtly sexual or moves in that direction. These are the situations where decoys will minimally support the ongoing activity without matching, supporting or endorsing the groomers' affective stance, nor do they cooperate in preference with the previous turn (Steensig, 2020, 249). *Lol* is frequently present in these situations where decoys are disaffiliating from the groomers' sexual propositions, as Example [2.a.] demonstrates.

Example [2.a.]

1 Decoy: so wut u doin
2 Groomer: strokin my dick
3 Decoy: **lol**
4 Decoy: why u doin taht
5 Groomer: im hard
6 Decoy: **lol**
7 Decoy: im sry
8 Decoy: **lol**
9 Groomer: yup
10 Decoy: so u gonna tlk 2 me when u get dun
11 Groomer: **lol**
12 Groomer: u wana stroke it for me
13 Groomer: **lol**
14 Decoy: if u wantd me 2
15 Decoy: **lol**
16 Groomer: lol
17 Groomer: w/e

In this example, stand-alone *lol* occurs a total of seven times and it is used by both groomer and decoy. The sequence is initiated by the decoy with the open question 'wut u doin' (line 1), a question designed to get the interlocutor to say more. The groomer's response on line 2 is a tranformative answer, because it aligns with the design of the question but disaligns in terms of content. The sexual explicitness of the response is highly transgressive and a rather unconventional answer to the question. The decoy strongly orients to the dispreferredness of the groomer's response with a stand-alone 'lol' (line 3) followed by the why-interrogative 'why u doing that' (line 4) suggesting that "the event to be accounted for does not accord with common sense and is, thus, possibly inappropriate or unwarranted" (Bolden and Robinson, 2011, 94). At the same time, the decoy's contribution on lines 3 and 4 is designed to function as a cross between going along and not going along, and thus the not going along part is softened.

In line 10 the decoy initiates a new sequence requesting confirmation that the groomer will continue their interaction, while completely avoiding the sexually explicit topic. This is underscored by the decoy's use of the phrase 'get dun' in reference to the sexual activity. The groomer disregards the request for a confirmation on line 11 with a stand-alone 'lol' followed by a continuation of the sexual talk (line 12) and then another stand-alone 'lol' (line 13). The decoy now aligns with the sexual talk, although in a highly conditional manner with 'if u wantd me 2' (line 14), followed by another stand alone 'lol' (line 15). This results in the groomer now explicitly orienting towards the decoy's lack of engagement and participation with a stand-alone 'lol' followed by 'w/e' (*whatever*) thus entirely dismissing the decoy's contributions and treating them indifferently.

So, we see here a series of stand-alone *lol*s used in one of two ways: 1) to indicate a marked negative stance towards the previous utterance, as done by the decoy for example in lines 3 and 6, or 2) to disregard or ignore the previous turn like the groomer does on line 11. The groomer's 'lol' on line 16 adopts both these functions, essentially taking a negative stance on the decoy's lack of appropriate response and dismissing the interaction.

Example [2.b.] below is not overtly sexual, but the exchange hints back at an earlier point in the conversation where the groomer had brought up sexual topics which are now being referred to indirectly by the decoy.

Example [2.b.]

1 Decoy: well, im lookin forward 2 seein u
2 Groomer: me too
3 Groomer: what would u like to do on saturday?
4 Decoy: all the stuff we talked abt
5 Groomer: like what?
6 Decoy: like everythin we talked abt **lol**
7 Groomer: like?
8 Decoy: omg, u no ….im embarrassed 2 say **lol**

In Example [2.b.] *lol* occurs twice on lines 6 and 8, both turns being illustrations of a decoy going along with a groomer's project, but not explicitly claiming to go along with it, which the groomer orients towards by pushing for specifics. On line 3 the groomer asks a question which is designed as a request for new information, i.e., information he does not appear to have existing access to (Stivers, 2022). However, the decoy's response on line 4 does not match this design, since it explicitly makes reference to 'stuff' they've already talked about. Using next-turn-proof procedure we can see that the groomer is in pursuit of a more elaborate answer (lines 5 and 7). The decoy does not provide any elaboration and first repeats a modified version of line 4 accompanied by a turn-final 'lol' on line 6. Then on line 8, at the groomer's insistance, accounts that she is 'embarrassed 2 say lol'. In both examples [2.a.] and [2.b.] the decoys are avoiding being explicit and using *lol* as a discursive means to accomplish that.

6.3. Calling out problematic or sexually transgressive responses

The third function I found *lol* to have was in the context of marking that a previous turn was problematic or sexually transgressive in some way. In example [3.a.] the groomer's turn on lines 5–6 is transgressive in nature, as it is a direct suggestion to meeting up with the purpose of having sex with no strings attached, evidenced by the use of the phrase 'hook up'.

Example [3.a.]

1 Groomer: Hey what are you doing tonight?
2 Decoy: Nm.. bored at home
3 Groomer: No plants tonight?
4 Decoy: Nope
5 Groomer: Wasn't too hook up?
6 Groomer: Want to hook up?
7 Decoy: **Lol**.. that was random
8 Decoy: Wut u mean by hook up?
9 Groomer: Meet up
10 Groomer: Or whatever you want it to mean

On line 7 the decoy does not respond to the groomer's inquiry, but instead takes a marked negative stance towards it, evidenced both by the initial 'Lol' and by the assessment that the question was 'random'. This negative assessment is

accomplished in a way such that it seeks to avoid shutting down the interaction and thereby accommodate to the groomer's project. We can see this avoidance in what comes next on line 8, where the decoy mitigates the negative assessment and asks for clarification.The groomer backpedals and the sexual 'hook up' is replaced with the more neutral 'meet up' (line 9) and further elaborates placing agency on the decoy by opening up for something potentially sexual 'whatever you want it to mean' (line 10). Groomers also use *lol* to call out problematic responses, as evidenced in Example [3.b.].

Example [3.b.]

1 Groomer (4:07 PM): I want to make you cum baby
2 Decoy (4:14): Soon
3 Groomer (4:15 PM): I can't wait do you like it when I call you baby
4 Decoy (4:16 PM): Sure
5 Groomer (4:17 PM): **Lol** sure?
6 Decoy (4:24 PM): Ya?
7 Groomer (2:24 PM): **Lol**

On line 5 the groomer explicitly calls out the inadequacy of the decoy's response on line 4 with 'Lol' followed by a questioning repetition of the decoy's 'Sure'. The decoy's response on line 6 does not deal with this however, leading the groomer to provide a stand-alone 'Lol' on line 7 thus taking a marked negative and dismissive stance towards the decoy's response, similar to what we saw in Example [2.a.].

6.4. "you're not a cop right?": responding to explicit verbalizations of suspicion

Another salient feature of the PJF dataset is that groomers will suddenly indicate they are suspicious of who they are chatting with, often by directly asking "Are you a cop?" or the like. This tends to happen when explicit sexual content has been brought up, or when the possibility of a physical meeting is being discussed. These confrontations obviously put the decoys' overall project at risk, and what always happens in these cases is that the decoys deny being law enforcement and sometimes provide additional reassurances of this. These denials and reassurances are often accompanied by *lol*. In example [4.a.] *lol* occurs turn-initially a total of three times and is only uttered by the decoy.

Example [4.a.]

1 Groomer (1:18 PM): i think its excitement and fear put together
2 Decoy (1:18 PM): **lol** i aint scary
3 Groomer (1:19 PM): but I could go to jail if I did anything with u
4 Decoy (1:19 PM): **lol** only if u went outside and yelled about it
5 Groomer (1:20 PM): do you really want me to come?
6 Decoy (1:20 PM): yeah i do
7 Groomer (1:20 PM): your not trying to trap me right
8 Decoy (1:20 PM): **lol** no

The 'lol' on line 2 co-occurs with a (false) assurance that the decoy is not 'scary' in response to the groomer's description of his feelings. On line 3 the groomer then expresses concern that he 'could go to jail', to which the decoy responds on line 4 with 'lol' followed by an implicit assurance that she would never tell anyone ('only if **you** went outside and yelled about it'). The groomer then asks for a disconfirmation on line 7 in which he directly asks whether she is trying to trap him. As with the other denials and reassurances, the decoy's disconfirmation on line 8 is preceded by 'lol'.

In Example [4.b] the groomer opens the sequence by asking the decoy if she is a cop, after which *lol* occurs four times and is uttered by both parties.

Example [4.b.]

1 Groomer (9:36 PM): you're not a cop right?
2 Decoy (9:36 PM): **lol** no
3 Groomer (9:36 PM): **lol**
4 Decoy (9:36 PM): i cant be a cop, im 13
5 Decoy (9:36 PM): and i wouldnt wanna b one anywayz when i grow up, i wanna be
6 a marine biologist
7 Groomer (9:36 PM): **Lol**
8 Groomer (9:36 PM): **lol**
9 Groomer (9:36 PM): cool

By directly asking the question of whether his interlocutor is law enforcement, the groomer is putting focus on the fact that the whole interaction is illicit, and that he knows it. The decoy makes a denial on line 2 which is accompanied by 'lol' and then provides a more elaborate explanation for why she is not a cop on lines 5–6. The groomer seems to accept this response on line 9 ('cool'), but not before uttering three stand-alone *lol*s on lines 3, 7 and 8.

7. Discussion

The quantitative overviews in Figs. 1–3 show that decoys use *lol* more frequently than groomers, which in itself is interesting, given that previous studies using the PJF dataset have not considered the content of the decoys' utterances at all (e.g. Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2016; Broome et al., 2020). In relation to RQ 1, the qualitative analysis revealed that the decoys' *lol*s

occur in situations where their behavior is challenged or when they are faced with transgressions that might compromise their project, i.e., their primary objective of catching and prosecuting sex-offenders. These transgressions may be sexual in nature as we saw in Example [2.a.], or may question the very foundation of the interaction as seen in Examples [4.a.] and [4.b.]. The four situations described in Section 6 tell us something important about the differences in how *lol* is used by groomers and decoys respectively.

This leads to RQ 2 which sought to find out whether there were any differences in how *lol* was used by decoys and groomers. In relation to this, the analysis revealed four different, albeit overlapping, functions of *lol* when used by decoys:

1. *Lol* may be used to preface accounts of not going along with the groomer, as shown in Examples [1.a.] and [1.b.].
2. *Lol* may itself mark not going along with the groomers' project, as shown in Examples [2.a.] and [3.a.].
3. *Lol* may be designed to reassure the groomer that there is no problem and that the interaction can continue, as shown in Examples [4.a.] and [4.b.].
4. *Lol* may go together with forceful, potentially detrimental rejections in order to mitigate them, such as the ones in [1.b.] and [3.a.].

In other words, *lol* acts as discursive support for the variety of avoidance and rejection strategies employed by the decoys to effectively balance their double-role as decoy and convincing child. But can this by itself account for why *lol* is used more than twice as often by decoys than groomers? There are several possible explanations here.

Given that groomers often pursue sexual topics in these conversations, it is unsurprising that the decoys must equally often deal with such transgressions, in the ways described above. Another explanation could be that decoys are actively and deliberately marking themselves as younger, i.e., as children. This is supported by an earlier CMC study examining an IM corpus consisting of 71 IM conversations between 17- and 20-year-olds (Tagliamonte and Denis, 2008). They found that the use of *lol* in IM conversations decreased systematically with age (Tagliamonte and Denis, 2008, 13). The decoys in this dataset also make use of a variety of other CMC affordances such as spelling, grammar and punctuation to position themselves as younger (recall e.g. lines 5 and 6 from Example [4.b.]).

As mentioned, the overall goal of this study was to test the usefulness of digital CA to analyze this kind of data, an approach which has revealed interactional aspects of groomer-decoy dynamics which were yet unexplored in previous scholarship. The functions of *lol* suggested by the studies outlined in Section 2.3. are empirically justifiable and undoubtably go a long way in explaining the groomers' use of *lol*, example [4.b.] being a good illustration of this: the *lol*s uttered by the groomer contribute to making that specific part of the interaction less serious, even though it could potentially be very serious. What my analytical approach has shown is that decoys can be equally strategic in using *lol* thus expanding our perspective on the discourse marker. Decoys use *lol* in sequences where they are accounting for why they are unable to participate in a sexual activity right now, which affects how the groomers respond to them and how they proceed. Because the decoys are posing as children they are essentially playing the unknowledgeable part. This is typically manifested in them taking a marked naïve stance towards the groomers' sexual advances, often forcing groomers to be even more explicit than they are already being. This naïve stance can also be explained on account of the decoys' role as decoy: in order to secure a prosecution, they need the offenders to be as explicit and unambiguous as possible about their intentions to engage in sexual activity with a minor, which they accomplish by requesting for explicitness. There are many instances of this type of behavior in the sample, one of them being present in Example [3.a.] where the decoy asks the groomer to elaborate 'Wut u mean by hook up?' (line 8).

This study has thus demonstrated that there is a qualitative gap in terms of how the PJF dataset has been previously studied, and that there are important insights to gain from applying microanalytic principles from CA to these types of interactions. These insights could prove useful in the comparison between 'real' grooming conversations, i.e., those involving children, vs. decoy conversations. It is important to stress, however, that my aim with this paper is not to suggest that my analytical insights can be used to detect decoys or detect deceptive language in any way. Nor is it intended to suggest that groomer-decoy interactions were chosen as an object of study *instead of* authentic child–groomer interactions. Rather, as part of the proof of concept, I chose to include the decoys to demonstrate that in order to understand how groomers groom, it is necessary to look at both parties in the conversation.

Given that the PJF dataset continues to be used in research on online grooming (Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2023), it is crucial to develop a more detailed understanding of the linguistic and interactional differences between authentic and non-authentic grooming conversations. This can help researchers better assess the applicability and limitations of findings drawn from such data. This point is further substantiated by Schneevogt et al. (2018) who examine how the PJF data differs from authentic grooming data and conclude that the PJF data "is not a perfect proxy for naturally occurring child abuse conversations" but "may still be useful for asking some important questions" (Schneevogt et al., 2018, 101).

Even though the PJF is no longer active, its ideologies towards these types of offenders certainly are (McDonald, 2014), and vigilante so-called 'pedo-hunter' groups are increasingly becoming a world-wide phenomenon (de Boeck et al., 2021; Tippett, 2024; Bolmgren, 2024; National Enhed for Særlig Kriminalitet, 2024 [Danish Special Crime Unit]). Some of these groups, e.g. the Swedish www.dumpen.se, also make use of decoys to contact men on social media, to then confront them with cameras and publish their message exchange and and personal information (Nilsson, 2022). With criminals increasingly moving their activities online and the advancement of social media and technology in general, it is unlikely that these

kinds of vigilante groups will cease to exist any time soon. This calls for scholars working in this area to stay alert to the linguistic features of these emerging multilingual decoy-groomer chats.

8. Conclusion

Overall, this study highlights the importance of including the decoys' utterances in the analysis of the PJF data, as opposed to looking exclusively at the offenders' language. Decoys are not passive participants in the conversations; they actively engage with groomers, employing a variety of discursive resources that aid them in balancing their role as decoy and pretend-child. This is significant given that some models of grooming language have been partially developed based solely on the offender's language in the PJF dataset (Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2016). In terms of the functions of *lol* the study also showed that mitigation is not the only function *lol* can serve in online grooming interactions, and that its functions vary according to who uses it.

Other studies that have looked at how children navigate these kinds of conversations linguistically, have found that children exhibit agency, though this is not to be understood as them having any blame for the situation (Lorenzo-Dus et al., 2023). Because decoys do not represent children, they have been consistently ignored when studying the linguistic features of the PJF dataset. However, this study has demonstrated the extent to which decoys shape their interactions with the offenders. My analysis has furthermore provided potential insights into the groomers' responses when encountering different forms of resistance (e.g. avoidance and disaffiliation) to their sexual advances.

Based on these considerations and on the findings of this exploratory study, I believe that sequential analysis of online grooming conversations is a promising avenue for future studies and would be a valuable contribution to the field of online child sexual offending. The next logical step is to apply this type of analysis to authentic grooming data.[2]

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Sofia Navarro Beck: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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[2] I have already undertaken this step as part of my current PhD project.

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My main research investigates the linguistic behavior of individuals who groom minors online, and my overall research question is: *what linguistic strategies do groomers employ when exposing minors to sexual content during online grooming?* Grooming is a manipulative and illegal communicative practice which poses an escalating societal threat. Although online grooming is a communicative practice, there is to date very little linguistic research into the phenomenon. Through digital conversation analysis my project aims to qualitatively study online grooming interactions from a linguistic perspective, with the overall aim of contributing to the development of research-based prevention programs and resources for minors, parents, and educators to recognize grooming language.

An additional research interest of mine concerns pseudo-science in the context of linguistic deception detection methods and tools offered to law enforcement. Currently I am investigating 911-Call Analysis, an investigative tool that purportedly allows law enforcement to find out whether the caller is guilty or innocent of the crime they are reporting. Drawing on linguistic theory from pragmatics, interactional sociolinguistics, and conversation analysis, I address the fundamental flaws in 911-Call Analysis and argue that the tool is based on pseudoscientific assumptions about language.

Fields of study: forensic linguistics, conversation analysis, digital conversation analysis, online sexual grooming discourse, pseudolinguistics.